

NORTHSTAR OUTFITTERS

Payments, Discounts, Gift Cards & Checkout Guide

Checkout behavior, payment troubleshooting, promotion rules, gift cards, taxes, and authorization holds

CUSTOMER SAFE

Version	2.8
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Purpose	Customer-facing reference for explaining checkout and payment behavior without exposing payment credentials.

Demo environment only. Northstar Outfitters, its customers, products, prices, orders, and commercial terms are fictional and created for SupportOps demonstrations.

Document Control

Audience	Customers and Support
Scope	Checkout, payment method display, failed attempts, duplicate-looking charges, promotions, gift cards, taxes/duties, and refund posting
Authority	Authoritative for policy/process. Actual payment methods, discount applicability, totals, and order/payment status are determined by Shopify/checkout and payment systems.
Review cycle	Quarterly or after a material policy/commerce change
Change control	Material changes require owner review and publication before becoming authoritative knowledge.
Knowledge governance Only documents marked PUBLISHED in SupportOps are authoritative for customer-facing answers. Current Shopify catalog, variant, price, availability, cart, and authenticated order state should be obtained from the approved Shopify MCP capability rather than inferred from static documentation.	

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1. Checkout Source of Truth

The active Shopify checkout is authoritative for the customer's current merchandise subtotal, discounts, shipping options, taxes, duties where applicable, and final payable total. Support documentation explains rules but must not override a valid live checkout calculation.

2. Payment Methods

Available payment methods depend on market, device, currency, and store configuration. Customers should use the methods displayed at checkout. Common card or wallet methods may be available, but Support should not promise a method that the active checkout does not show.

3. Failed Payment

1. Ask the customer to confirm billing details and available funds without sharing sensitive card data.
2. Retry once after correcting obvious input issues.
3. If the same payment repeatedly fails, suggest another method shown at checkout.
4. Do not ask for full card number, CVV, one-time password, or banking credentials.
5. If an order/payment state appears inconsistent, escalate with order/payment identifiers rather than secrets.

4. Authorization Holds

A pending card entry can be an authorization rather than a completed charge. Banks control how quickly unused authorizations disappear. Support should verify the actual order/payment state before telling the customer they were charged twice.

5. Duplicate Charge Concerns

Observation	Possible explanation	Support action
Two pending entries	Multiple authorizations / retry attempts	Verify successful order/payment objects before concluding duplicate capture
Two completed charges	Possible duplicate payment/order	Escalate payment investigation
One pending + one completed	Authorization plus captured payment	Explain pending hold may release; verify objects
No order but bank entry visible	Authorization without completed order possible	Verify checkout/order state and escalate if unresolved

6. Discount Codes

A discount applies only when its configured conditions are met. Conditions can include products, minimum spend, customer eligibility, market, usage limits, dates, or other rules. The checkout result is authoritative for whether a code applies.

- Enter codes exactly as provided.
- Expired or exhausted codes cannot be manually treated as active without an approved exception.
- A code applying to some items does not imply it applies to the entire cart.
- Support should explain the observed eligibility condition rather than invent a replacement discount.

7. Promotion Stacking

Unless a promotion explicitly allows combination, customers should not assume multiple discount codes can be stacked. Gift cards are a payment/value instrument and can be treated differently from promotional discount codes depending on checkout configuration.

8. Gift Cards

- Gift-card value can be applied only where the store/market supports it.
- Never request a customer to paste the full gift-card code into an insecure or public channel.
- If a gift-card balance appears incorrect, escalate with masked/approved identifiers.
- Refund behavior for gift-card-funded purchases follows the configured payment/refund workflow.

9. Price Changes

Catalog prices and promotions can change. A previous product-page screenshot does not create an automatic right to a historical price. When a price changes after an order is placed, the confirmed order total remains the reference for that order unless an approved adjustment is made.

10. Taxes and Duties

Taxes and duties depend on destination and commerce configuration. Checkout is the authoritative calculation. Support can explain what is shown but should not provide personalized tax/legal advice or manually recalculate government charges from memory.

11. Currency

The storefront may display prices according to market/currency settings. The customer's bank may apply its own conversion or foreign transaction fee. Northstar cannot guarantee a bank's conversion rate.

12. Refund Posting

A refund being marked as processed by the commerce/payment system means Northstar has initiated the return of funds. The customer's financial institution can take additional business days to display the credit.

13. Payment Security

Never request secrets

Support must never ask for a full card number, CVV, online-banking password, one-time code, or wallet authentication credential.

- Use only approved secure checkout/payment flows.
- Mask sensitive identifiers in tickets when possible.
- Treat unexpected requests to "verify" payment by sending secrets as suspicious.
- Escalate suspected account/payment compromise to the approved security workflow.

14. Troubleshooting Matrix

Customer issue	Check	Knowledge response	Escalate when
Code says invalid	Checkout discount result/conditions	Explain eligibility or expiry if known	Configuration appears inconsistent
Payment failed	Order/payment state	Use another displayed payment method after basic checks	Repeated failure with inconsistent state
Charged twice	Order/payment objects	Distinguish authorization from captured charge	Two completed charges or unclear state
Total changed at checkout	Cart, shipping, tax, discount	Explain components shown	Checkout calculation appears malformed
Refund not visible yet	Refund state/date	Explain bank posting time	Beyond normal period with processed refund

15. FAQ

Q. Can Support take my card number over chat?

A. No.

Q. Why does my discount work on one item but not another?

A. Discount conditions can target specific products/collections or require eligibility conditions.

Q. Can I combine two promo codes?

A. Only if checkout configuration explicitly allows the combination.

Q. Why is the bank amount slightly different from the store currency?

A. Your bank may apply currency conversion or fees.

Q. Does a pending bank entry mean the order succeeded?

A. Not necessarily. Verify the actual order/payment state.

Appendix A - Checkout Total Anatomy

Component	Source	Support note
Merchandise subtotal	Current cart/catalog	Can change if quantity/variant changes
Discount	Promotion configuration	Eligibility can depend on products, dates, market, usage
Shipping	Checkout destination/method	Do not quote static shipping price if checkout differs
Taxes/duties	Checkout/market rules	Do not manually provide tax advice
Gift card/value	Applied payment value	Treat secrets as sensitive
Final total	Checkout	Authoritative amount before customer confirms payment

Appendix B - Payment Lifecycle Scenarios

Customer sees	Commerce state	Interpretation
Bank pending entry, no order	No completed order/payment	May be authorization; do not call it successful purchase
Order confirmed, payment complete	Successful financial state	Normal
Two pending entries, one order	One successful order; multiple auth attempts possible	Verify captures before duplicate-charge claim
Two completed captures for one intended purchase	Payment discrepancy	Escalate immediately
Refund processed, no bank credit yet	Refund exists	Explain posting delay; monitor threshold

Appendix C - Promotion Eligibility Examples

Promotion condition	Example customer outcome
Minimum spend \$100	\$95 eligible merchandise subtotal does not qualify
Selected collection only	Code may apply to shoes but not bottle/accessory
One use per customer	Previously redeemed account may be ineligible
Active dates	Code outside validity window is not active
No stacking	Second promo code may replace or fail rather than combine

Appendix D - Secure Support Checklist

- Never ask for full PAN/card number.
- Never ask for CVV.
- Never ask for OTP or wallet approval code.
- Never ask customer to “test” security by sharing screenshots containing full secrets.
- Use order IDs and payment-system identifiers that are safe for internal support.
- Redact unnecessary sensitive details from attachments/tickets.

Appendix E - Escalation Examples

Issue	Escalate when
Promo code rejected	Configuration appears inconsistent with documented active offer
Gift card problem	Balance/redemption state cannot be explained without secure investigation

Issue	Escalate when
Duplicate charge	Two completed charges/captures appear likely
Refund delay	Refund is processed but well beyond normal posting expectations
Checkout total bug	Tax/shipping/discount calculation appears internally inconsistent

Appendix F - Failed Checkout Playbook

6. Confirm the item/variant is still purchasable and cart is valid.
7. Ask customer to review billing/shipping information without sharing secrets.
8. If checkout shows a clear eligibility message (for example promotion minimum), explain it.
9. For a card decline, suggest the customer contact their bank or use another method shown at checkout.
10. If multiple attempts create inconsistent order/payment states, stop retrying and escalate.

Appendix G - Refund, Dispute, and Chargeback Boundary

A merchant refund and a payment dispute/chargeback are different processes. Support should not tell a customer to open a bank dispute as a substitute for the normal return/refund process. If a dispute already exists, route the case to the appropriate payments workflow so duplicate refunds are avoided.

State	Support implication
Normal refund requested	Follow returns/refund policy and payment workflow
Refund already processed	Explain posting time; do not issue a second refund
Bank dispute already open	Escalate to payments; avoid duplicate merchant resolution
Customer threatens dispute due to unresolved service issue	Continue support resolution professionally; do not retaliate or make unsupported payment promises